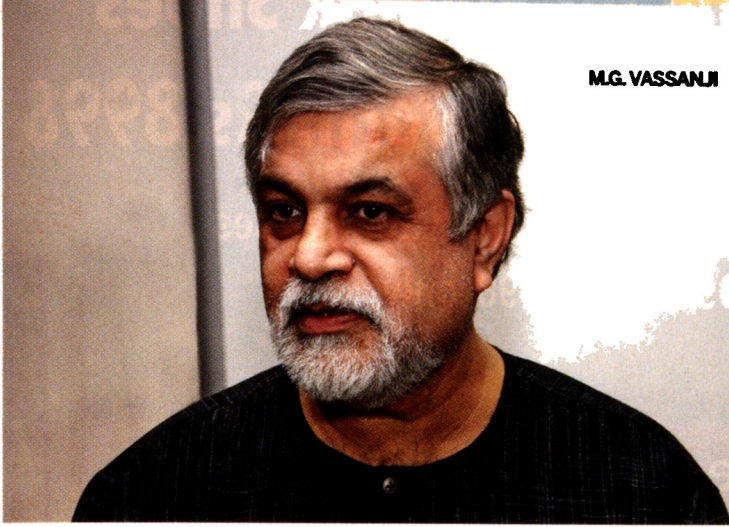




M.G. VASSANJI

Trapped in PARADOX

Intrusive history spoils the journey of a novelist in search of his ancestral identity

| By Dillip Bobb |

Towards the end of his narrative, the author arrives at the village in Gujarat his ancestors left two generations earlier and says that he experiences no "Kunta Kinte moment". The reference is to Alex Haley's *Roots*, the seminal work written in 1976 which led to a sub-genre of displaced authors exploring their past. *Roots* was a Black American's search for identity and cultural moorings in the land of his origins, Africa, and the ancestor he unearths, Kunta Kinte. To use a phrase currently in vogue, it was his backstory. Haley uncovered for an entire race their cultural heritage.

A Place Within is M.G. Vassanji's *Roots*, minus the larger context, a quest for a lost homeland, a lost identity and a forgotten heritage. He and his parents were born in Africa. He studied in Oxbridge and settled in Canada as nuclear physicist and later, a writer of fiction. Having tasted literary success, the urge to discover his origins proved a powerful muse. Starting from 1993, he began a series of visits to India, some by invitation, others on his own. On each trip, he kept a diary of his travels, observations, conversations, encounters and experiences. That collection of diaries literally forms the spine of

this book, his first attempt at non-fiction.

Vassanji's four earlier books have sealed his reputation as a highly accomplished storyteller in the fiction mode. His non-fiction, like his journey of discovery, is less sure-footed. It's a narrative that switches between personal quest, history, travelogue and pilgrimage without quite finding its roots, so to speak. There are some wonderful passages and he is a powerful, evocative writer, but at the end, there is too much that is personal, too much recorded history and some visible confusion over the audience he is addressing.

He describes his journey as part pilgrimage and partly a revelatory voyage. It is both of those and also a search for the soul—his and the country his grandparents left. It's a journey worth taking and at first, the submergence of a wide-eyed traveller whose cultural and ethnic reference points come from Bollywood movies and an ancestral, mythical memory of India strikes literary resonance as he plunges headfirst into the chaos, colour and contradictory realities of his original homeland. For him, as he writes, India seems to do something to the soul, give it a sense of homecoming, another kind of nostalgia. During each visit, he seeks it more intensely than ever, without quite finding what it is he is looking for.

The India he does find is paradox personified, alien, yet familiar, frustrating and enlightening, friendly yet cruel. Added to the contrarian mix is his ethnic background; he is a Muslim, a Gujarati Khoja, a Canadian citizen who finds himself in India during bloody communal upheavals, the Babri Masjid, Gujarat, Mumbai riots, causing some friction and unease with his dual identity: an outsider trying to become an insider and being a Muslim. Such encounters are literary speedbreakers on his journey of self-discovery which he clearly finds difficult to negotiate. His visits, however, continue as he tries, in his words, "to place myself historically".

History is what defeats him, at least for an Indian audience. The book's pace and thematic journey is interrupted by lengthy passages on Indian, especially north Indian, history. For an Indian audience, it is irksome and unwieldy. The narrative strings 12 years of notes, journal entries and observations and it would have been better served without the history lessons. He does try to explain his obsession with history as being reflective of unfinished migrations, "the perpetual homelessness in my life", but never convincingly enough. It is, for all that, an interesting journey, best defined as travelogue. The other journey, finding his identity, remains largely unfinished. ■



**A PLACE WITHIN:
REDISCOVERING
INDIA**

by M.G. VASSANJI
Penguin/Viking
Price: Rs 599
Pages: 361